



Receiving Confirmation

How experienced auditors make sense of AI-generated agreement with a judgment they had already formed

RESEARCH QUESTION

How do experienced auditors experience and make sense of receiving an AI-generated conclusion that confirms a judgment they had already formed?

1 · PROBLEM STATEMENT

An auditor on a recurring engagement has always carried a prior conclusion forward. What is new is that an AI system now produces a conclusion of its own, and sometimes it agrees.

Research on AI and auditor judgment has focused primarily on the extent of reliance, which a survey can measure. The lived experience of receiving machine agreement with a judgment already formed remains unexplored.

Firms and regulators are writing AI-use policy on the assumption that a human reviewer still exercises independent judgment.

2 · PURPOSE STATEMENT

The purpose of this phenomenological study is to understand how experienced auditors experience and make sense of receiving an AI-generated conclusion that confirms a judgment they had already formed.

3 · PHILOSOPHICAL ASSUMPTIONS

SOCIAL CONSTRUCTIVIST · INDUCTIVE ONTOLOGICAL

Multiple realities. Auditors' accounts of the experience are the data, not a proxy for one correct account.

EPISTEMOLOGICAL

Knowledge comes from first-person accounts in semi-structured interviews.

AXIOLOGICAL

The researcher is a career auditor who built an AI review tool: insider access and insider bias, managed through reflexive memos and a confirmation hazard log.

METHODOLOGICAL

Inductive phenomenology across individuals at different firms.

4 · METHODOLOGY: APPROACH

Phenomenology (Creswell & Poth, 2024). The question asks about experience and meaning making across individuals, which is what phenomenology is for.

- Not case study: the phenomenon crosses firms, with no bounded site
- Not grounded theory: the question is about experience, not process

5 · METHODOLOGY: DATA COLLECTION

ELIGIBILITY IS THE PHENOMENON

Participants can recall a specific time AI output agreed with a judgment they had already formed. They do not need to have interpreted it in any particular way.

- Five or more years in audit or risk assurance, recurring engagements
- Criterion sampling plus referrals, all screened the same way; a short screening question tested first
- About 10 to 15, guided by the depth and richness of accounts
- Semi-structured, recorded interviews; protocol piloted first

6 · METHODOLOGY: DATA ANALYSIS

FIVE ACTIVITIES · NVIVO

- 1 Managing and organising. NVivo, named file plan, secure storage.
- 2 Reading and memoing. A dated reflexive journal, kept as evidence.
- 3 Describing and classifying. Horizontalisation, meaning units, clusters.
- 4 Developing interpretations. Textural and structural, then a composite.
- 5 Representing. A thematic map and a composite narrative.

7 · ETHICS AND VALIDATION

- Informed consent and IRB determination before any contact; pseudonyms, no firm detail
- Member checking of each participant's own textural description
- External reviewer reads purposefully chosen transcripts, including a disconfirming one, with the analytic memos
- Confirmation hazard log entries tied to specific analytic decisions in the audit trail

8 · DESIRED CONTRIBUTIONS

TO PRACTICE

Shows what human review of AI output is actually like, for firms and regulators relying on it.

TO ACADEMIA

Distinguishes the auditor's experience of agreement from measures of reliance.

9 · POTENTIAL LIMITATIONS

- Retrospective accounts of a past experience
- Insider researcher: bias managed, not eliminated
- Small purposive sample; not intended to generalise

AI DISCLOSURE

Generative AI (Claude, Anthropic) helped draft and lay out this poster from the author's proposal and protocol, and checked clarity. The research question, design decisions and interpretations are the author's (FIU Graduate School AI policy).

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